

THE LOST JAMAICAN · FREE SUBSCRIBER PACK

The Photoreal Portrait Prompt

One master prompt that produces a person who looks photographed rather than generated — plus the reasoning behind every clause, so you can bend it to any subject instead of copying it blindly.

The master prompt

Paste this as-is, then change only the **[bracketed]** parts.

Editorial portrait photograph of [AGE]-year-old [DESCRIPTION OF PERSON], with [SKIN TONE] skin, [HAIR: length, colour, texture, how it is worn], [EYE COLOUR] eyes, [ANY DISTINGUISHING FEATURES]. A calm, closed-mouth expression, looking directly into the lens. She looks like a real person who was photographed, not a campaign model.

Framing: [SHOT SIZE] in a 4:5 portrait composition, the face occupying most of the frame. Hair falls naturally, with fine flyaway strands and baby hairs visible at the temples and hairline.

Skin, described honestly: thousands of distinct pores across the cheeks and nose, fine vellus hair and peach fuzz catching the side light, scattered natural pigmentation, a few tiny red capillaries near the nostrils, two or three small blemishes, gently uneven skin tone, mild natural redness beside the nose, and real skin oil reflecting light along the nose bridge and forehead. Lips show fine vertical lines, natural folds, slight asymmetry between the two sides, a minute dry patch, and a delicate trace of moisture where they meet. Some areas of skin are smoother, others carry more texture. Makeup is minimal: a barely detectable skin tint and a thin clear balm producing a few uneven specular highlights.

Light: soft diffused daylight as though from a large north-facing window, entering slightly from camera left, with gentle shadow falloff on the far cheek. Neutral colour reproduction. Plain pale-grey seamless backdrop.

Camera: full-frame digital, 85mm lens at f/8, ISO 100, sharp focus held across the face with natural depth falloff toward the ears and hair.

The skin is entirely unretouched, with every pore, fine hair, blemish and uneven patch left exactly as a camera would record it.

What I changed, and why

This is a rewrite of a prompt that was already close. Four changes did the work.

1. The long list of prohibitions came out

The original ended with a wall of **"absolutely no plastic skin, no AI smoothing, no poreless surfaces, no waxiness, no beauty filters..."** Generative models do not reliably process negation. Naming a concept increases the chance it appears — the same reason "an empty street, no people" puts people in the street.

The rule: never describe the failure. Describe the success so specifically that the failure has no room left. "Thousands of distinct pores, mild redness beside the nose, a small dry patch on the lower lip" cannot coexist with plastic skin, so you never have to forbid it.

One short positive closing line does the whole job: *"The skin is entirely unretouched, with every pore, fine hair, blemish and uneven patch left exactly as a camera would record it."*

2. "8K macro" came out

"8K" and "macro" are not photographic instructions, they are marketing words, and models associate them with over-sharpened, hyper-clarified stock imagery — the exact plastic look you were trying to avoid. Real cameras are specified in millimetres and f-stops. **85mm at f/8, ISO 100** says far more than "8K" ever will.

3. Imperfections got locations

"A few tiny blemishes" is decoration. **"A few tiny red capillaries near the nostrils" and "skin oil along the nose bridge and forehead"** are instructions. Anchoring each imperfection to a place on the face is the single biggest realism gain in the whole prompt.

4. Beauty language came out of the subject line

Opening with "a beautiful woman" pulls the model toward the symmetrical, airbrushed average of every beauty photograph it has seen. Describe the features and let the viewer decide. *"She looks like a real person who was photographed"* does more for realism than any negative clause.

The three dials, in order of effect

DIAL	WHAT IT DOES
Located imperfections	The strongest single lever. Move each flaw to a named place on the face.
Real camera language	Focal length, aperture, ISO and a named light source. Drop resolution buzzwords entirely.
Uneven surface	"Some areas smoother, others with more texture." Uniformity is what reads as synthetic.

Adapting it

- **Men:** add facial hair by the strand — "individual stubble hairs with visible gaps along the jaw, a few grey hairs at the chin." Vague beards render as texture soup.
- **Older subjects:** name the lines and where they sit — "fine crow's feet from the outer corners, a deeper line across the left side of the forehead."
- **Deeper skin tones:** state the tone explicitly and describe the sheen rather than the shadow. Never let the model lighten the subject — and check the finished frame against your reference rather than trusting the prompt.
- **Wider shots:** add real hands — "visible knuckle creases, tendons, short unpolished nails." Hands are where generated people usually give themselves away.
- **Keep the expression closed-mouth** until you are happy with the face. Teeth are the second most common tell.

When it still looks generated

- **Skin too even?** You are missing located imperfections, not detail. Adding "more detail" makes it worse.
- **Waxy sheen?** Your light is too soft and too frontal. Move the key further to the side and let one cheek fall off.
- **Eyes look dead?** Ask for a specific catchlight: "a single soft rectangular catchlight in each eye from the window."
- **Face too symmetrical?** Ask for it directly: "the two sides of her face differ slightly, as real faces do."